

Gothic cathedrals

With their towers, flying buttresses and tracery (stone window framings), Gothic religious monuments were the supreme expression of Christianity in architecture. They represented a synthesis of God, humanity and nature, a blend of symbolism and efficient structures, and size became a dominant feature. From outside, the towers and pinnacles form intricate silhouettes against the sky as they soar towards Heaven; the vast, airy interiors, with hazy or coloured light pouring through the stained glass, seem similarly unearthly.

It was technical advances of the 12th century that elevated cathedrals from the heaviness of Romanesque to the lightness of the Gothic style. A major change was from thick to thin walls: the tonnage of roofs and towers was now transmitted to the ground not through stout walls but via a load-bearing 'skeleton' of pointed arches, ribbed vaults and multiple rib-like flying buttresses. Rain was shed from lead-covered roofs and spouted away from the walls through chutes or gargoyles.



Chartres Cathedral, 1194–1250